

Got The Sniffles? New Study Says You Can Blame Your Kids!

By: Chaz Wilke - Staff Writer



For those of you that have kids, you may already know that your offspring can get you sick. "I call them the plague monkeys. I was hardly ever sick before they arrived," [explains](http://bit.ly/1f-BBPDy) (<http://bit.ly/1f-BBPDy>) Gizmodo commenter Allan Jones.

And he's not alone.

Parents across the nation know the bittersweet feeling of sending their kids back to school. This is because whatever relief they get having the kids busy all day can quickly get wiped away as soon as one child returns home with a fresh case of the sniffles.

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New Oxford Journal Study

The University of Utah’s BIG LoVE (Better Identification of Germs-Longitudinal Viral Epidemiol-ogy) study recently released its data. The findings reveal that as a family grows so does the per-centage of weeks each year that someone in the family is carrying a viral illness.

For childless households, the infection rate is a meager 3-4 weeks per year, while households with six children revealed that the family would be living with at least one member sick for a whopping 45 weeks each year! That leaves less than two months each year where everyone will be technically illness free.

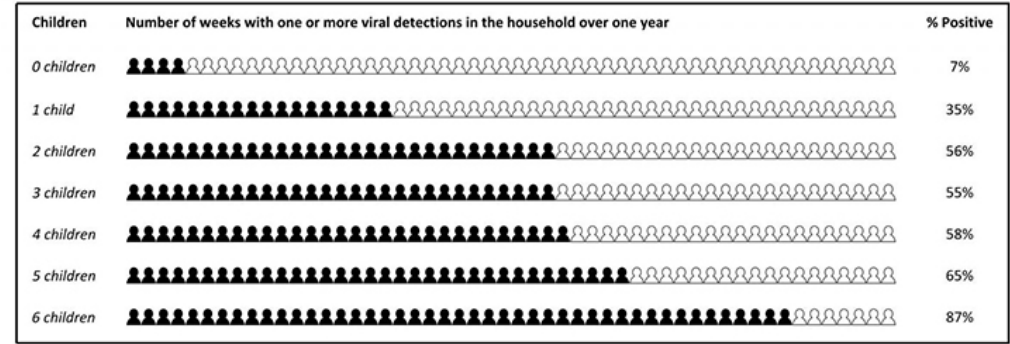


Image Credit: University of Utah

The research also revealed that while an increase in children meant an increase in individual sickness across the board, it also showed that parents would get sick “1.5 times more frequently than similarly aged adults who did not live with young kids,” says (<http://bit.ly/1hWVZJS>) the University of Utah.

The study used a sensitive diagnostic test called PCR (Polymerase Chain Reaction), which regis-ters and identifies different viruses and bacteria. This sensitive test was able to pick up positive infections from a surprising number of participants with a frequency that seemed to defy logic.

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The study's co-author Dr. Carrie Byington, professor of pediatrics at the University of Utah and co-director of the Utah Center for Clinical and Translational Science [explains](http://bit.ly/1Eej-09Z) (<http://bit.ly/1Eej-09Z>): "When we were able to put all of the data together and analyze it, we found that about half of the time that we were able to detect a virus in the nose of an individual, [but] they had no symptom."

Those symptoms Dr. Byington speaks of include things like coughing, sneezing, fever and runny nose. This means that carriers can potentially distribute a virus without recognizing that they are carrying a viral infection. So other members of the family can contract a virus without knowing that the non-symptomatic family member they are interacting with is actually sharing their cold.



What can you do to protect yourself?

This newfound data proves that it can be next to impossible to know who's got a viral infection and who doesn't, so it isn't as easy as just avoiding the sickie. There are a few tips that can help keep you from falling ill that don't include locking the person with a cold in their room for weeks on end.

First, consider placing a few **UV air purifiers** around the home. This can help remove airborne particulate matter, which can help save healthy family members from walking into a cloud of cold germs. "The UV air purifier is capable of reducing the growth of, and even eliminates, germs, viruses, fungi and mold spores from a home's indoor air," [reports](http://bit.ly/1hD2WA8) (<http://bit.ly/1hD2WA8>) *The San Diego Union-Tribune*.

Wash your hands (<http://wb.md/1EfCXsq>) and consider hanging separate towels for each member of the family, or consider getting a disposable container of paper towels for the bathroom and kitchen. There is a wide array of options to choose from in that category, including anything from the *fancy* (<http://bit.ly/1V5bUUW>) to the *utilitarian* (<http://amzn.to/1V5bYUA>). Illnesses can be highly communicable on hand towels, especially when family members reach for a still-damp kitchen or bathroom towel to dry their hands during high traffic periods in the household.

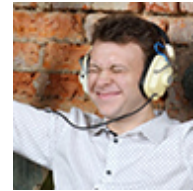
Refrain from touching your face. It sounds simple but you might not even realize how often you touch your face every day. Studies show that on average we touch our faces *3.6 times per hour* (<http://bit.ly/1Ltgc1>). Since our hands pick up all kinds of germs on everyday household items, touching your face is the quickest way to introduce those germs into your body that get you sick.

If you find yourself with a cold, cover your mouth using the "**Dracula Cough**," where you cough into the pit of your elbow. This prevents germs from getting on your hands and being spread to surfaces you touch, and loved ones.



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If you feel like you're coming down with a cold, it's debatable whether taking vitamin C will help, but **Zinc** might. "Zinc administered within 24 hours of onset of symptoms reduces the duration of common cold symptoms in healthy people," concludes a [clinical study](http://1.usa.gov/1NPPuCX) (<http://1.usa.gov/1NPPuCX>) performed in 2013.

But, this benefit comes with a caveat that it might not work for all people and the benefits should be tempered against the understanding that there will be side effects, which include a bad taste in the mouth and nausea and also will not prevent spreading the infection to others.

Get plenty of sleep. Sleep replenishes your immune system. If you feel rundown, make it an early night and get a full eight hours of sleep. A recent study focused on the link between rest and the immune system in mice. "The research found that the circadian clocks of mice control an essential immune system gene that helps their bodies sense and ward off bacteria and viruses," [reports](http://bit.ly/1LtiHmK) (<http://bit.ly/1LtiHmK>) Mercola.com.

Maintain a positive outlook! It might sound crazy, but a positive outlook on life can actually be a boon to your immune system. A research team [reported](http://wb.md/1JPHnZg) (<http://wb.md/1JPHnZg>) in 2006 that "people who were generally happy, lively, and calm — were better able to fight off both cold and flu viruses than people who were anxious, hostile or depressed."

Takeaway

"A lot of families go through wave after wave of illness. In fact, some of the kids we monitored had symptoms for 20 to 25 weeks in a row," says Dr. Carrie Byington. This type of research using a PCR-based diagnostics test is one of the first of its kind. It provides deeper insight on a relatively known fact that children tend to get sick often. But, as the frequency of these tests continue to grow and a larger test base is sampled, we may still learn more details concerning the communicability of virus and bacteria borne illnesses.

Learning more about how these illnesses spread is the first step in understanding how to stop them. This information should come as welcome news to all those parents of large families out there who might be at wits end as we return once again to the dreaded cold and flu season.

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